EDIFACT message

The basic standardization concept of EDIFACT is that there are uniform message types called United Nations Standard Message (UNSM). In so-called subsets, the message types can be specified deeper in their characteristics depending on the sector. The message types, all of which always have exactly one nickname consisting of six uppercase English alphabets. The message begins with UNH and ends with UNT

- Service messages
  To confirm / reject a message, CONTRL and APERAK messages are sent.
  - CONTRL- Syntax Check and Confirmation of Arrival of Message
  - APERAK - Technical error messages and acknowledgment
- Data exchange
  - CREMUL - multiple credit advice
  - DELFOR- Delivery forecast
  - IFTMBC - Booking confirmation

EDIFACT Segment

It is the subset of message. A segment is a three-character alphanumeric code. These segments are listed in segment tables. Segments may contain one, or several related user data elements.

EDIFACT Elements

The elements are the piece of actual data. These data elements may be either simple or composite.

An excerpt from an EDIFACT message might be:

DTM + 11: 200 606 200 730: 203'

This whole line is called a segment. The meaning of each code is as follows:

- DTM is the segment identifier and it indicates that the following data is date / time information.
- 11 is a data element. In this example, a qualifier describes what kind of event is meant. The code 11 means: time of dispatch / delivery of goods.
- 200606200730 is another element. Here it represents the date in the format CCYYMMDDHHMM.
- 203 is also an element. 203 is an identifier for the date format.

In this example, 203 means that the date is in the format CCYYMMDDHHMM (as of D.18B, CC – century, YY – Year, MM- Month, DD – Date, HH – Hour, MM – Minute)

EDI Separators

EDIFACT has the following punctuation marks that are used as standard separators.

Character	Uses
Apostrophe '	segment terminator
Plus sign +	segment tag and data element separator
Colon :	component data element separator
Question mark ?	release character
Period .	decimal point

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